SALESFORCE EXPERIENCE CLOUD · ONE-PAGE SUMMARY · OCTOBER 2026

Customisation tiers for Salesforce websites

Where design work ends, where developer effort begins, and where customisation starts to put Salesforce upgrades at risk. Client work is custom by default: the questions are effort, and whether a screen restructures or reaches into a standard component.

	TIER · WHO	WHAT CHANGES	CONSTRAINTS · WATCH FOR	UPGRADE RISK
1	**Configure** Admin, designer	Pages, standard components, navigation and audiences in Experience Builder. The Theme panel sets brand colours, fonts and heading styles, published as `--dxp` hooks. Anything an admin should change later belongs here.	Only the options Salesforce exposes: template layouts, standard sections and columns, and each component's Builder properties.	None
	BEFORE TIER 2 Align the Figma library to the design system: variables named after real hooks, SLDS colour steps, roles not hues, and only the states, anatomy and sizes components have.			
2	**Style** Designer, working from a verified hook inventory	VALUES AND PUBLISHED NAMES ONLY, NO NEW CSS RULES • **Global tokens** `--slds-g-*`: the theme. Reach every component at once • **Component hooks** `--slds-c-*`: per component. Only the ones its own stylesheet reads work. A developer preview in SLDS 2 • **SLDS utility classes** `slds-*`: spacing, text, grid, named in markup	NO HOOK EXISTS FOR label size and weight, checkbox size, border width, input padding, focus-ring shape, hover elevation. PROVE IT A hook can exist and do nothing: read the rendered value. Utilities have no responsive spacing or gap. PRODUCTION Component hooks and re-pointed globals: prototype-only, in the styling register.	Low: re-verify each release
	DEVELOPER GATE Code from here down. Expected for client work: budget from the start, sized by effort. **Tests:** sets a value or names something published → Tier 2; writes a new CSS rule, class or selector → Tier 3; changes a component's structure → Tier 4; reaches into its internals → Tier 5.			
3	**Layout** Developer, designer	Custom theme layouts (header, footer, page frame) and page layouts, built from standard base components with regions authors fill in Builder, **and the CSS classes we write to style them**. `::part` only as a signed-off last resort.	Deployed as metadata, not edited in Builder. Responsiveness and accessibility become ours. Classes are project-prefixed and never select Salesforce classes or internals.	Low
4	**Component** Developer	**Compose** (the normal case, low effort): standard components assembled into a new one with data mapped in, such as a card repeater or a two-column detail view. **Rebuild** (the exception, decided explicitly): a standard component restructured, or rebuilt because no hook reaches its look.	Browser security model and allow-lists. Performance, accessibility and caching become ours. A rebuild also takes on keyboard behaviour, validation and screen-reader support.	Low, owned by us
	UPGRADE GATE Depends on Salesforce internals that can change without notice. An architecture approval.			
5	**Override** Developer	Reaching past a standard component's supported interface: CSS aimed at internal markup, **private styling hooks** (`--slds-s-*`, `--_slds-*`), scripts that alter the page after load, undocumented behaviour.	WARNING SIGNS selectors on classes we did not write · `!important` · a private hook · found by inspecting markup · a copied and edited standard component. Breaks silently; not covered by support.	**High**

What building it showed

86%
of the button design's values reached

70%
of the form controls' values reached

26
Figma variables named a wrong hook on first import

The gap is not effort: it is properties no hook reaches. Decide it per value: **accept** the component, **change** the design, or **fund** a Tier 4 rebuild. Never drift into Tier 5.

Recommendations

1. **Align the design system** before designing screens, and audit each import.
2. **Design to what ships**, from a verified hook inventory, not the published list.
3. **Review before building, measure after:** read rendered values in a browser.
4. **Budget for the developer gate** from the start; rebuilds and the upgrade gate need explicit approval.
5. **Hand over the prototype and its styling register:** every token and hook set, retested each release.

Summary of *Customisation tiers for Salesforce websites*. Evidence from the MSD LWR prototype: Figma design-system import and skinning of lightning-button and five form controls, measured in headless Chrome; conversations with two Salesforce architects.